

Title: Wave Management for Top Laners in Laning Phase

Score:

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I accidentally wound up writing a guide to laning phase wave management when trying to be detailed for a friend and thought I would share it.

****Disclaimer:****

I do not pretend to be "good" at League of Legends or the best at explaining things. I believe I have done a decent job explaining the basic mechanics that govern how waves operate in laning phase but do not cover every situation. This is based on my personal experiences and hence might not be completely or correct or comprehensive. That said, I hope a few of you can learn a thing or two and drastically improve your game play.

Proper wave management in laning phase is extremely important in top lane. When done correctly, you can dismantle your enemy without even touching them. When done poorly you can wind up in situations where you are unable to acquire gold and potentially die/lose your turret. There are 3 big things (in my opinion) you have to know, but each one of these has a few finer details we will delve into!

1. Which way is the wave naturally pushing?
2. How to build, prevent, and break freezes.

3. What to do with the wave?

****WHICH WAY IS THE WAVE NATURALLY PUSHING?****

This is probably the first step to understanding wave management is wave size which can be impacted by minion type and creep position. We will first address how wave size effects the way the wave naturally will push, differences in minion pushing power, and then address how wave position affects the wave size needed to control this push.

To start, suppose all minions are in the middle of Top Lane. If the enemy has 7 creeps and you have 6 creeps, the wave is going to push to you without external interactions. This is because the enemy wave puts out more DPS and therefore the wave is going to push to you. Assessing the number of minions is the first step in determining which way the wave is pushing.

The next basic thing you have to consider is minion types. Melee creeps have the least pushing power (sans baron), ranged creeps have more, and cannon creeps have the most BY FAR. My **personal** rule of thumb is to assume that it will take ~4 ranged creeps to match the pushing power of a cannon creep when trying to determine which way a wave in the center of a lane will push. We will address how this impacts freezing in the next section.

The last thing you have to consider is the wave position. This is because of what I like to call **Reinforcement Timing** and is the least obvious step for proper wave management. In reality however, it is quite simple. Take the following situation, the wave is just outside of YOUR turret, it is an evenly matched wave with 6 creeps (3 melee, 3 ranged) on both sides. When the minions come from base, your minion reinforcements will arrive first, creating a period where your wave has higher

DPS. This period of higher DPS will also create a focus fire effect as the enemy creeps die quicker. This will cause the wave to push harder as your creeps all have longer lifetimes and the wave shape tends to focus one target when a wave begins pushing.

The rule of thumb here is that a wave will always push towards the opposite side of the map given an evenly matched wave. We will get a little bit more specific about numbers in the next section as we address freezing.

****HOW TO BUILD, PREVENT, AND BREAK FREEZES****

So now you know the basic principles behind what governs a wave's natural tendencies. Now we need to know how we apply these governing ideas in order to create advantages for ourselves and deny the enemy gold/play making opportunities. This is generally done by freezing, but I feel this term implies sitting with the wave at your turret. Freezing can be slightly more broadly defined as follows: *using the results of reinforcement timing and imbalanced wave strengths in order to keep a wave pushing towards a player.*

BUILDING A FREEZE

Freezing a wave can be incredibly impactful if done properly. You can deny your enemy gold and experience by freezing, or you can use a frozen wave to prevent the enemy team from picking up easy kills on you while behind. Generally speaking freezing the wave near your turret is good multiple of the following conditions are met:

- * Your enemy cannot roam well due to lack of teleport or innate champion characteristics
- * You have significant kill pressure on your enemy which will enable you to deny them

experience/gold

- * You are behind and at risk of being solo killed/easily ganked further up the lane
- * The enemy (including their jungler) cannot dive you without losing on a cross map play (higher elo)

This list is not exhaustive but it will give you a good starting point of things to consider. To create a freeze all you need is for the wave to naturally push to you. OPPORTUNITIES to create a freeze through minion imbalances (generally caused by your enemy mismanaging the wave) or through you properly crashing a wave into the enemy turret. Not every freeze opportunity can translate into a good freeze due to back timings, jungler positions, and your lane opponent. These are more matchup related issues and will not be covered.

In terms of minion imbalance, you generally only need to pay attention to caster creep and cannon creep imbalances as melee creeps generally only survive in waves that are very large and are obviously pushing hard. We will address the case of the wave being on your half of the lane and the case of the wave being on your enemies half of the lane. The only game play "mechanic" you need is to simply be able to last hit the creeps as late as possible. When the wave is near your turret knowing whether you can freeze or not is relatively simple and is a DIRECT RESULT of wave size, minion type, and Reinforcement Timing.

****Note:** Remember that cannons push hard. I have found ~4 caster creeps to be equivalent to one cannon, your results may vary**

If the enemy wave has 3 caster creeps more than your wave, you will be able to freeze until the next cannon wave as your waves reinforcements won't be powerful enough to break the freeze. If the enemy has 4 caster creeps you may be able to freeze through a cannon wave if the wave is closer to the center of the lane, you last hit at the very last second, and the caster creeps that alive

are high HP. 5 caster creeps is the golden number for myself personally and will allow you to easily freeze indefinitely if that is your goal.

When the wave is near the enemy turret building a freeze from a evenly matched wave/larger enemy wave is easy. Reinforcement Timing will cause the wave to slowly push to you and doesn't take a lot of effort. You may even wind up needing to trim the wave if your enemy is slow pushing (and can't kill you) and you want to maintain a freeze. Making this evenly matched/imbalanced wave near the enemy turret is done by getting a wave to crash under tower. The timing of this crash and wave size will determine whether or not the wave will push back to you and how quickly the wave will push back to you. This will be covered shortly.

While all of this is very good theory, it is easy to get caught up in the detail. Actually executing a freeze is very simple, and some of the information in the next section will help you as well. Essentially all that is required is that you withhold your using AOE spells on the wave and carefully last hit when the enemy wave is naturally pushing to you. Remember that this natural push can happen from an even wave near the enemy turret, or when your opponent has more minions near your turret. A helpful tip for maintaining or creating a freeze is using your champion to draw the enemy minions up the lane so they do not hit your turret before reinforcements arrive. While you may need to trim the wave afterwards to prevent it from pushing too quickly, this is a very effective strategy. If you know your enemy is going to base this can open opportunities for you to stop their recall, force their TP, or get a base+experience lead with TP.

It is important to remember that freezing is not always a good option. Indefinitely freezing can harm your team if you opposing laner is trekking into your jungler or roaming onto your teammates. It can also cause you to miss a lot of farm and experience if you have to teleport to save a fight or get dove. Potentially costing you a turret as well. These are things that you learn with experience and

change from match to match.

PREVENTING AND BREAKING ENEMY FREEZES

This section is less detailed but still has some valuable information I have learned from my own experiences and watching others. We will begin by defining a proper push. A proper push is a push that causes ALL THE MINIONS in your wave to aggro on your enemies tower.

This is extremely important to follow when first learning wave management in lane. If you fail to execute a proper push without a sufficiently large wave+your opponent being unable to respond,it is extremely likely you will wind up in a situation where Reinforcement Timing will result in the wave remaining frozen on the enemy side of the map. This is due to your minions whittling down the health of your opponent's reinforcement waves, causing a wave imbalance when your minion reinforcements arrive. While this isn't always true, it is a good rule of thumb

Improper pushing is the single biggest mistake myself and many others make. The result is the frustrating situation where it always feels like you can't quite get your wave under tower and makes you very vulnerable to being ganked/poked out of lane if you aren't ahead. In order to *prevent* your enemy from attaining this advantageous wave position, you simply assess how fast your can clear a wave.

If you can clear a wave quickly enough for your minions to properly push then it is easy to prevent this from happening. However when the wave is close to your turret you might not want to immediately try to hard push as this can prevent you from executing a proper push. Sometimes the correct solution is to allow the wave to slow push (via patient last hitting) in order to allow your wave to move up the lane. This causes your wave to hit the next reinforcement wave OUTSIDE the

enemy tower so you can properly crash the minions under tower afterwards. An added benefit to slow pushing is that a large wave allows you to safely play up in lane. Minion damage early game is absolutely huge, and if your enemy tries to fight you in a 12 strong minion wave they will always lose without a well executed gank or an already large gold lead.

Something that I think is important to note is executing a proper push with a larger wave is what is referred to as "bouncing a wave". Since you have a lot of minions hitting the enemy turret, one of two things happens. Your reinforcements will either completely go under tower, automatically causing a huge wave imbalance after the turret clears and the wave will push back to you afterwards. The second is that your reinforcement casters get stuck outside of the turret while the melees die. This will also cause the wave to push back to you. This will allow you to constantly keep the wave in an advantageous position.

Breaking an enemy freeze is difficult if you are weaker in than your enemy, hence the emphasis on prevention. Breaking an enemy freeze generally requires you being able to walk up and execute a proper push which can easily result in death/loss of summoners. Generally the smart things to do is either bait your enemy into accidentally pushing their wave with AOE, being able to execute a proper push with your HP followed by an immediate base, or calling your jungler to help you.

These are the basics of freezes and the more general idea of manipulating natural wave tendencies.

****WHAT TO DO WITH THE WAVE****

This is the harder question to answer and due to the sheer number of factors involved. Some aspects have been touched on but we do not have a complete answer. It is highly match-up

dependent and changes drastically as the game progresses. It is impossible to answer for every situation, so there are only three questions that matter at the end of the day (in my personal order of importance):

1. Does this hurt my team?
2. Do I get ahead from this?
3. What opportunities does this give my opponent and how do I respond if they take them?

Learning the answers to the questions in all situations requires active focus and thinking EVERY GAME. But simply being an active thinker and trying to apply your knowledge will give you MASSIVE improvement over a very short time. I will leave you with a few more tips before casting you out for ingame experience.

Generally speaking, initiating a trade level 1 without a larger wave/enemy overextending is a bad idea. You don't have a lot of health/resistances, and your auto attacks will draw the aggro of your enemies creeps if you walk forward to trade. In my experience, forcing heavy trades level 1 isn't a good idea on most melee champions and generally requires you to have an offensive summoner or your opponent to not respect your minions. If you are playing a ranged champion however, it is easier to control the wave and harass your opponents when they walk up without taking large amounts of creep damage. Having wave control is key to being able to being the aggressor in early trades.

Sometimes it is also important to take a bad trade to ensure that the minions push in the direction you want them to. Situations where this is applicable can be around important level powerspikes or attaining a proper push. Often times this involves using your AOE abilities to both harass your enemies and push the lane simultaneously, but other times can involve you intentionally taking

damage to prevent/break a freeze. You have to be careful though when intentionally taking bad trades as it opens you up to being solo killed if you under estimate your opponent/the enemy jungler is near.

****SOLO KILLS AND YOU****

The last major tip is deals with the proper course of action that you should take after solo killing your opponent in lane. When you solo kill your opponent there are four questions that you should ALWAYS ask yourself.

- * Which way is the wave pushing?
- * Do you need to execute a proper push in order to force their TP/deny gold and experience? (This can lead to taking turret the later laning phase lasts)
- * Can the enemy jungler stop your push and potentially kill you?
- * If you do not have a good back, can you roam on other lanes or kill their jungler?

This first question should be self evident. If the wave is frozen on your side, you might only need to trim the wave or immediately back in order to gain a large advantage over your lane opponents. But if the wave is pushing to your enemy, executing a proper push is crucial to denying your enemy and hence why you always ask the second question. It is worth noting though that sometimes the wave will be pushing to your enemy and you will not have the CLEAR speed in order to execute a proper push, thus giving your enemy a freeze. If you think enemy can maintain the freeze either due to jungle pressure or innate match-up characteristics, you should immediately back, buy a control ward

in addition to your items, and teleport back to lane to maintain your advantage. Otherwise it is very easy for you to get into a huge farm and experience deficit (especially if you are a melee champion)

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Now suppose you need to execute a proper push and have the ability to do so. Gaining yourself a teleport, gold, and experience advantage is ALWAYS a good thing. However just because you can execute a proper push after solo killing doesn't mean you should! The next thing you have to be worried about is the enemy jungler. If they can stop the push AND kill you, you can ruin your game with 2 seconds of bad decisions. Your enemy will freeze, you will be down 2 levels because you died as well, and you will be at the mercy of your team for a long time. However, if the wave is large enough (say 12+ creeps), it is almost always valuable to get that wave under turret. Even if you die to their jungler, it is a kill worth of gold and possibly a level of experience that you will be gaining over your opposing laner. You must also consider whether or not the wave gives you the ability to fight the enemy jungler. If so you can continue executing the push.

Side note, if you are into a ranged matchup as a melee and get behind, it is important to have excellent wave control and never let them freeze unless you can all in them and win. You will never farm again without your jungler breaking the freeze. Your team will flame you. And you will not have a good time. ^I^^hate^^Quinn.

The last thing to consider is whether or not you should roam after a proper push. While this is under the solo kill section, it also applies to when you can quickly execute a proper push the second enemy minions arrive to lane, or you crash a large wave under their turret. If you are healthy and do not have a good spike from items in base, you should always consider roaming. Especially from a top lane perspective, your roams are less expected than that of a support or a mid laner. Very often you can catch people by surprise and net yourself and your team big advantages by simply

attempting to roam when you know the wave will push back to you later due to your proper push. If you would like to know of a streamer who does an excellent job at this DM me, but I am not going to advertise a stream in this main post! It is something that is easier to learn while watching it happen as opposed to just reading about it.

That concludes the last of the tips I have! I hope you have learned a thing or two and I appreciate any criticism you can give!